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Thinking West: Pakistan, Afghanistan, and West Asia

Background: Post-Islamist Openings

Independence and Partition disrupted India's long tradition of engagement to its west, the broad region ranging from Afghanistan and Iran to the Arabian Peninsula and North Africa. If India's renewed engagement with its east after 1991 was motivated primarily by economic opportunity, and subsequently assumed a stronger security-oriented character with China's rise, its engagement to its west moved in almost the opposite direction. For decades until the mid-2010s, India's westward relationships were often seen through a Pakistan prism. Competition with Islamabad for influence within the Arab and Islamic worlds predominated, and India's approach to Afghanistan from the late 1970s onwards was frequently an extension of its Pakistan policy. Such factors also imposed limitations on its relationship with Israel. In many ways, the regional dynamics were influenced by questions concerning Islamism.

It should be emphasized at the outset that Islamism is distinct from Islam. Broadly, Islamism is the idea that society should be ordered according to rules laid down in sharia, or Islamic religious law drawn from the Quran, the Hadith, and Islamic jurisprudence. [1] What makes Islamism distinct from many other forms of religiously-inspired politics is the alternate sense of international order that some of its adherents espouse: that is, the idea of a religious *ummah* (or 'community') that transcends national boundaries and —by some interpretations—transcends the very idea of the sovereign state. This is very different from, say, the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation,